Covert War: After the Bay of Pigs

"As long as Castro thrives, his major threat – the example and stimulus of a working Communist revolution – will persist," one U.S. government report warned after the Bay of Pigs.[48] After the invasion attempt, according to one study, the Kennedy Administration turned to covert action with renewed vigor. "Virtually all agencies of the federal government were enlisted … The State Department, Treasury, FBI, Commerce, Immigration, Customs were brought together in departmental committees to come up with measures that could damage Cuba."[49] As Robert McNamara explained, "we were hysterical about Castro at the time of the Bay of Pigs and thereafter," and there was clear pressure to "do something about Castro."[50]

Shortly after the U.S. defeat the CIA opened a new station on the University of Miami campus to coordinate the secret war.[51] The station's operating budget was over $50 million a year, and it had a permanent staff of over 300 American case officers who oversaw several thousand Cuban agents. It also coordinated international efforts through CIA stations over the world to gather intelligence, convince other countries to break relations with Cuba, and stimulate anti-Castro propaganda, as well as to "persuade, bribe, or blackmail" Cuban officials to defect when they traveled abroad.[52]

What former CIA Deputy Director Ray Cline described as "punitive economic sabotage operations" were the main activities. Agents in Europe sabotaged cargoes and sought to dissuade shippers from going to Cuba. A special staff in Langley, Virginia worked on projects ranging from placing contaminants in Cuban sugar shipments bound for export, to damaging machinery headed for Cuba.

> We were really doing almost anything you could dream up. One of our more sophisticated operations was convincing a ball-bearing manufacturer in Frankfurt, Germany, to produce a shipment of ball bearings off center. Another was to get a manufacturer to do the same with some balanced wheel gears…[53]